Style Guide

Here lie the heretofore-unwritten rules and styles we use when writing documentation, issues, pull requests, and other forms of written expression.

References

- Plain Language guide
- GitHub list of supported languages

Capitalization

Follow standard capitalization for written work such as comments, documentation, reports, and emails, namely that

> words are lowercase unless there is specific guidance to capitalize them. For example, capitalize the first word of a sentence, unless the sentence begins with the name of a person whose name starts with a lowercase letter.

Reference: APA's capitalization guidelines

When an object being referenced has a nonstandard capitalization, defer to its capitalization. For example, GitHub has a capital letter mid-word.

Use uppercase for abbreviations, including technical protocols such as HTTPS and SSL.

Please note that this guidance is specifically for *written work such as documentation* and that code capitalization has its own standards that vary by language.

Repositories

All repositories should be public.

Whether creating new repositories or transferring existing repositories, remember that we work in the open by default. For a discussion of the rare cases in which we might use private repositories, read our open source policy.

Repository naming

Use a repository's name to describe its purpose. Names should be:

1. Descriptive
2. Readable
3. Consistent
4. Contextual
5. Future-friendly
6. Extensible
7. Reusable

Avoid references to pop culture or other implicit references. GitLab has a good guide on using inclusive language in documentation.

Specifically, when naming a repository:

- Use lower case
- Use dashes
  - For readability, where spaces would otherwise separate words
  - Avoid underscores, which require extra keystrokes

Repository settings

Specify code owners in each repository's `.github/codeowners` file to make sure that changes and pull requests are reviewed by people familiar with the codebase. This way, we'll catch more problems before they get into the protected branch.

- Set a minimum of two code owners for all repositories.
  - Add or edit each repository's `.github/codeowners` file.
- Set up branch protection.

Titles and subjects

Use title case for the main title of a document.

Headers and headings

Use sentence case for headings within a document that are not the inital document title.

When referencing an object or another document, use the capitalization of the referenced item, such as "GitHub" or "the Style Guide".

Use both opening and closing octothorpes (#) to indicate the Markdown header level. Our Markdown linting enforces this as well.

For example:

- `### Use variables to configure pipelines ###`
- `## Using the Style Guide ##`

Lists

Use bulleted lists unless order matters, in which case use numbered lists.

Always capitalize the first word of list items, unless they’re parameters or commands that are in backticks, or a similar situation.

List punctuation

Periods or no periods?

- Use periods at the end of bullets that are full sentences.

- Omit periods at the end of partial sentences.
- Match the rest of the bulleted or numbered list as much as possible.

Code blocks

When formatting code blocks, use the formatting that best highlights the syntax in the code block.

We generally use code blocks for scripts, command-line usage, and when showing file contents like configuration files.

Scripts

- Use `shell` formatting for shell scripts
  - `shell` is also aliased as `sh`, `bash`, `zsh`, and others
- Use language-specific formatting, such as `python`, for blocks with scripts written in specific languages
  - Reference the GitHub list of supported languages

Command-line

- `console` is most effective at highlighting a command *and* its resulting output, like this:

  ```
  $ the_first_command
  the output
  more output
  $ the_second_command
  yet more output
  ```

- `shell` should be used for result-less commands, *especially* if there is any shell-fu like pipes, file redirects, shell variables, etc. to apply syntax highlighting so the reader is more aware of the magic happening

File contents

- Extension-specific formatting, such as `hcl` for Terraform, should be used